

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN TURKMENISTAN

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the air, water, and deserts of Turkmenistan — but here the honest starting point is unlike any other in this series, because Turkmenistan is one of the most closed and tightly controlled states on earth, where independent organising inside the country is nearly impossible and genuinely dangerous, and where the real work of opposing environmental harm must be done largely from outside, on behalf of a silenced people and a harmed world. Turkmenistan sits atop some of the planet's largest natural-gas reserves, and its aging, poorly maintained, and leaking gas infrastructure has made it one of the very worst **methane super-emitters** in the entire world — its fields, flare stacks, and pipelines venting into the sky a potent climate super-pollutant that satellites now measure directly from space, in staggering quantities that rival the emissions of whole industrial nations. It is also a land of environmental strain in other ways: a desert country drawing down shared rivers to irrigate its cotton, a shrinking inland sea on its border, and a vast burning gas crater set deep in its sands. But its people cannot speak of any of it: there is no independent press, no political opposition, no civil society, and those who dare to criticise the state face prison or worse. There is no landmark victory to point to, and the levers are almost entirely external. But those external levers — running through the satellites that no secrecy can blind, the world's climate diplomacy, the buyers of the gas, and the exile diaspora — are real.

Because the harm is a globally significant climate pollutant that no secrecy can hide, the tools are almost entirely external, and they are real. The distinctive lever is the **satellite evidence**: Turkmenistan's methane leaks are visible from space, so the harm cannot be hidden by the state's secrecy — a foundational fact no denial can erase. The **world's methane diplomacy and pledges** — the global pledge to cut methane the state has not even joined, and the climate bodies behind it — give diplomatic and institutional pressure a closed state still feels. The **buyers and partners of the gas** can be pressed to demand lower-methane production — a lever on the trade that funds the state. The **exile diaspora and documentation** carry the case from outside. And the **transboundary water frameworks** reach the shared rivers and the shrinking sea the country strains. These tools are general — the satellite evidence, the climate diplomacy, the gas buyers, the diaspora, and the transboundary frameworks reach the country's various harms, with the methane the central case. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly.

Turkmenistan is among the most repressive states on earth, where criticism can bring imprisonment, disappearance, or worse, and where even the families of exiles abroad may face reprisal, so the work must be done entirely from outside and protect everyone — those inside and their families abroad — absolutely. There is almost no space to organise inside. The state has not even joined the world's basic methane pledge. And the levers are almost entirely external. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — the methane harm measured and exposed by satellite, the state pressed through the world's methane diplomacy, the gas buyers pressed to demand cleaner production, the case carried by the diaspora, the shared waters raised through the transboundary frameworks — entirely from outside, and protecting everyone absolutely. Above all, protect the people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot organise safely inside one of the world's most repressive states, and you must never endanger anyone inside or their families abroad. What can be done runs almost entirely from outside, on a harm that

no secrecy can hide: expose the methane leaks the satellites measure from space; press the state through the world's methane diplomacy and pledges; press the gas buyers and partners to demand cleaner production; carry the case through the exile diaspora; and raise the shared rivers and shrinking sea through the transboundary frameworks — all from outside, and protecting everyone absolutely.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Turkmenistan is among the hardest and most dangerous settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. There is almost no space to organise inside; criticism can bring imprisonment, disappearance, or worse; even families of exiles may face reprisal; the state has not even joined the world's methane pledge; and the levers are almost entirely external. This is not a fight for domestic organising. It is external work on a satellite-visible harm, whose realistic prize is the methane exposed and pressed, the buyers moved, and the shared waters raised — while everyone inside and their families abroad are protected absolutely.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Domestic power is closed and absolute, so the decisions a careful effort can reach run almost entirely outside: the **satellites and scientific monitors** that measure the methane; the **world's climate diplomacy and methane bodies**; the **buyers and partners of the gas**; the **exile diaspora and international advocates**; and the **transboundary institutions** of the shared rivers. Nothing runs safely through domestic organising. Map the external decision-makers, and never seek to organise inside, before spending a week on it.

How the Harm Moves — and Where You Jump In

The methane vents from the fields and pipelines into the sky, measured from space; the gas flows out to its buyers; the rivers are drawn down for cotton; the sea shrinks. You enter through the satellite evidence that exposes the methane; through the world's methane diplomacy and pledges; through the gas buyers and partners; through the diaspora that carries the case; and through the transboundary frameworks for the shared waters. Enter entirely from outside, on the harm no secrecy can hide, and protect everyone.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the gas: the fields and pipelines that leak the methane, and the buyers and partners who fund the state and can demand cleaner production. Follow the satellites: the methane they measure from space, beyond the state's power to hide. Follow the diplomacy: the world's methane pledge the state has spurned, and the pressure it can still feel. Follow the water: the shared rivers drawn down for cotton, and the shrinking sea. The leverage lies in the satellite evidence, the methane diplomacy, the gas buyers, and the transboundary frameworks.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is nonexistent, so the watchers a careful case engages are the satellites and scientific monitors, the world's climate and methane bodies, the gas buyers and partners, the exile diaspora and international advocates, and the transboundary institutions. The satellite evidence gives the external watchers a handle no secrecy can blind.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No effort inside Turkmenistan safely organises against the state, and honesty requires saying so plainly — the space is closed and the danger grave. What the external tools can deliver is the methane exposed and pressed, the buyers moved, and the shared waters raised. The single most decisive move is **exposing the satellite-measured methane and pressing it through the world's methane diplomacy and the gas buyers**, because the harm is globally significant and visible from space regardless of the state's secrecy, and because that exposure and pressure can be applied from outside without endangering anyone inside. The satellite evidence is the distinctive lever; the methane diplomacy and gas buyers the pressure; the diaspora and transboundary frameworks the reach. The realistic prize is exposure and external pressure, not a domestic stop.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions, all external. **What is the harm?** — the methane super-emissions, the drawn-down rivers, the shrinking sea. **What measures it?** — the satellites that see the methane from space. **What framework reaches it?** — the world's methane diplomacy and pledges, the transboundary water frameworks. **Who can be pressed?** — the gas buyers and partners. **How is everyone protected?** — the overriding question, inside and among exiles' families. Pick the harm the satellites, the methane diplomacy, or the gas buyers can reach safely, from outside.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case carefully, entirely from outside. **Layer one: the harm** — the methane leaks the satellites measure, the drawn-down rivers, the shrinking sea, documented from space and by international monitoring. **Layer two: the framework and the responsible party** — the world's methane pledge the state has spurned, the gas buyers who fund it, the transboundary institutions of the shared waters. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which satellite monitor, climate body, gas buyer, or diaspora channel to engage, and the absolute discipline of never exposing anyone inside or their families abroad. A case built on the satellite-visible methane, carried from outside, is one no secrecy can dismiss and one that keeps everyone safe.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **methane record**: the satellite measurements of the leaks, the worst-emitting fields and pipelines. Gather the **diplomacy record**: the world's methane pledge and bodies, and the state's non-participation. Gather the **gas record**: the buyers and partners who fund the state and could demand cleaner production. Gather the **water record**: the shared rivers and shrinking sea, and the transboundary frameworks. Gather the **channel record**: the satellite monitors, the climate bodies, the diaspora. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm nothing exposes anyone inside or their families.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE EXTERNAL COALITION

The coalition here is entirely external, because open domestic organising is impossible and dangerous. Build it from the **satellite and scientific monitors** who measure the methane; the **world's climate and methane bodies and diplomats**; the **gas buyers and partners** who can demand cleaner production; the

exile diaspora and international advocates; and the **transboundary water institutions**. Frame everything around the satellite-visible methane and the shared waters; never organise inside; and protect everyone inside and their families abroad absolutely.

STEP 4: THE SATELLITE EVIDENCE, THE METHANE DIPLOMACY & THE GAS BUYERS — WORKING ENTIRELY FROM OUTSIDE

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but external and constrained, so the prize is exposure and pressure, not a domestic stop.

The Satellite Evidence

The distinctive lever is the **satellite evidence**: Turkmenistan's methane leaks are visible from space, so the harm cannot be hidden by the state's secrecy — a foundational fact no denial can erase. Ground everything in the methane the satellites measure.

The Methane Diplomacy and the Gas Buyers

The **world's methane diplomacy and pledges** give a closed state pressure it still feels, and the **buyers and partners of the gas** can be pressed to demand lower-methane production — a lever on the trade that funds the state. Press the diplomacy and the buyers.

The Diaspora and the Transboundary Frameworks

The **exile diaspora and documentation** carry the case from outside, and the **transboundary water frameworks** reach the shared rivers and shrinking sea. Pursued together — the satellite evidence, the methane diplomacy and gas buyers, and the diaspora and transboundary frameworks — these levers expose and press the harm from outside, while protecting everyone.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always externally and carefully. **For the satellite and climate monitors**: here is methane to measure and expose from space. **For the world's methane diplomacy**: here is a super-emitter that has spurned your pledge. **For the gas buyers and partners**: here is gas whose methane you should require to be cut. **For the transboundary institutions**: here are shared rivers and a shrinking sea the country strains. **For the world**: here is a climate super-pollutant no secrecy can hide. **The golden rule**: expose the satellite-measured methane, press the world's diplomacy and the gas buyers, carry it through the diaspora and transboundary frameworks — and never expose anyone inside or their families abroad.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with the greatest care, and entirely through external channels. Frame any attention around **the satellite-visible methane**: a climate super-pollutant venting into the sky in quantities that rival whole nations, measured from space regardless of the state's secrecy — never in a way that exposes anyone inside or their families abroad. Carry it through the international climate press, the satellite monitors, the diaspora networks, and the gas buyers' scrutiny. A few cautions govern everything: never expose anyone inside or their families; work only from outside; and let the satellite evidence and the world's methane pledge carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message external, satellite- and diplomacy-grounded, and absolute in protecting everyone inside and their families abroad.

8A — To a satellite or climate monitor: request or present the methane measurements of the worst-emitting fields.

8B — To a methane-diplomacy body: set out a super-emitter that has spurned the world's pledge.

8C — To a gas buyer or partner: require lower-methane production as a condition of the trade.

8D — On the shared waters: raise the drawn-down rivers and shrinking sea with the transboundary institutions.

8E — To an international climate body: present the globally significant methane harm and request pressure.

8F — To the exile diaspora: coordinate the documentation and advocacy from outside.

8G — To an international advocate: share the satellite case and request engagement.

8H — To the international public: summarise the satellite-visible methane super-emissions — exposing no one inside or their families.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: assemble the satellite measurements of the methane leaks; identify the gas buyers and the methane bodies; write the one-page external case. **The fastest-moving levers:** the satellite evidence, the methane diplomacy, and the gas buyers. **Emergency action:** where a super-emitting field or a buyer is identifiable, the satellite evidence and the buyer or methane body are the sharpest, safest handles, all from outside. Throughout, never expose anyone inside or their families, and work only externally.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but closed and repressive to an extreme degree. Recognise it plainly and accept the aim — not a domestic stop, but the methane exposed and pressed, the buyers moved, the shared waters raised. Lean only on the external levers: the satellite evidence no secrecy can blind, the world's methane diplomacy, the gas buyers, the diaspora, the transboundary frameworks. And accept the honest limits — there is almost no space inside, the state has spurned the world's pledge, the levers are external — while still exposing the harm from outside and protecting everyone inside and their families abroad.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL REPRESSION — AND WHO IS AT RISK

Here the danger is not hidden corruption but a state among the most repressive on earth, where criticism brings imprisonment, disappearance, or worse, and where even the families of exiles abroad may face reprisal. Respond only through the **entirely external channels:** the satellite evidence, the methane diplomacy, the gas buyers, the diaspora, the transboundary frameworks. Never through domestic organising. **On safety and care:** this is the guide's most important note by far, and it governs everything.

Turkmenistan is among the most repressive states on earth; criticism can bring imprisonment, disappearance, or worse, and even families of exiles abroad may face reprisal. Work entirely from outside, through the satellite, diplomacy, gas-buyer, diaspora, and transboundary channels; never organise inside; never expose anyone inside or their families abroad; and gather nothing that could endanger anyone. Protection is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, entirely from outside. The satellite-measured methane feeds the diplomacy, the gas-buyer pressure, and the international exposure at once; the diaspora carries the case; the transboundary frameworks raise the shared waters; nothing exposes anyone inside. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the satellite methane record; **months two onward**, press the methane diplomacy, the gas buyers, and the transboundary institutions, and mobilise the diaspora; **through the long external effort**, sustain the exposure and pressure. The core discipline: external, satellite-grounded, diplomatically and commercially pressed, and absolute in protecting everyone inside and their families abroad.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Turkmenistan is among the hardest and most dangerous grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim the state can be safely opposed from within, or that a domestic victory exists, or that there is any space to organise inside — none of that is true, and the danger to anyone inside and their families abroad is grave. What it claims is real: that Turkmenistan's methane leaks are a globally significant climate harm the satellites measure from space regardless of the state's secrecy; that the world's methane diplomacy and pledges give a closed state pressure it still feels; that the gas buyers and partners can be pressed to demand cleaner production; that the exile diaspora carries the case from outside; and that the transboundary frameworks reach the shared rivers and shrinking sea. These tools are general, reaching the country's various harms, with the methane the central case. The levers are external, and the prize is the methane exposed and pressed, the buyers moved, and the shared waters raised — not a domestic stop. For one of the most closed states on earth, whose harm to the whole world's climate no secrecy can hide, that external work — carried from outside on a harm the satellites reveal, and protecting everyone inside and their families abroad absolutely — is not a lesser ambition. It is the only responsible and effective one.